Executive Summary – Airbnb Market Intelligence

Nov 10, 2026 · @Tunde

This report looks at about 280,000 homes listed on Airbnb in 10 cities around the world, and 5.4 million guest reviews written between November 2008 and March 2021. It explains in plain words what the numbers show and what we suggest doing about it. No charts are needed to follow it.

Key findings

1. **One city holds a quarter of all the homes.** Almost 1 in every 4 listings is in Paris (64,690 homes), nearly twice as many as New York, the next biggest. Hong Kong is the smallest, with only about 1 in 40. Because Paris is so big, it can drown out the other cities in any overall number, so each city needs to be looked at on its own.
2. **Most guests get a whole home to themselves.** About 2 in 3 listings are an entire house or flat, and nearly all the rest are a single room inside someone's home. Hotel rooms and shared rooms are rare: fewer than 4 in every 100. Half of all listings are entire apartments, so that is where hosts face the most competition.
3. **A few very expensive listings make "average" prices misleading.** Imagine nine people earning ₦100,000 a month and one earning ₦10 million: the average says everyone is rich, but the typical person is not. Airbnb prices work the same way. In every city the average price is 1.4 to 2.7 times higher than the typical price (the one in the middle when all prices are lined up), and Rio de Janeiro and Cape Town are the most distorted. So this report uses the typical price. A typical night costs €80 in Paris and €65 in Rome, the only two cities that share a currency. In Paris, a whole home costs about one and a half times a private room (€82 against €53), and bigger places that sleep more guests cost more.
4. **Hosts are more responsive in some cities than others.** Almost everywhere, hosts reply to between 8 and 9 out of every 10 guest messages. Saying yes to booking requests varies more: hosts in Bangkok accept about 9 in 10 requests, but hosts in Rio de Janeiro only about 3 in 4. Rio de Janeiro and Hong Kong are below average on both replying and accepting.
5. **The kind of host differs a lot by city.** In Mexico City, about 1 in 3 listings is run by a "superhost", Airbnb's badge for its best-rated hosts; in Sydney and Paris, only about 1 in 8. In Hong Kong the average host runs 3 to 4 listings, which suggests businesses

renting out several properties. In Paris the average host has just over 1, so it is mostly ordinary people renting out the home they live in.

6. **Nearly a third of listings have never had a review.** 86,156 homes, about 3 in every 10, have no reviews at all, meaning no recorded guest activity. Activity also varies by city: a typical listing in Rome has about 40 reviews, so guests come and go often, while one in Istanbul has only about 8.
7. **Travel grew for ten years, then COVID-19 hit.** The number of reviews written rose every single year, from a handful in 2008 to 1.6 million in 2019. In 2020 it fell by more than half. Guests are generally happy: the average rating is 93 out of 100, and homes with lots of reviews are almost always rated highly.

Recommendations

1. Help hosts in Rio de Janeiro and Hong Kong respond to guests better.

- *Why:* hosts in these two cities reply to fewer messages (about 83 in 100, against about 87 on average) and accept fewer bookings. Rio's hosts turn down about 1 in 4 requests.
- *What to do:* try a support programme in these two cities first, with simple onboarding, reminders to reply quickly and guidance on accepting more requests.
- *How we'll know it worked:* check each city's reply and acceptance rates every three months. If they rise towards the 10-city average within six months, faster than in similar cities without the programme, it is working.

2. Help the homes that have never had a guest review get their first booking, starting with Istanbul and Rio de Janeiro.

- *Why:* about 3 in 10 homes have no reviews at all. In Istanbul a listing averages only 8 reviews and in Rio 12, against 19 overall.
- *What to do:* offer first-guest discounts, give hosts a simple checklist (good photos, clear description, sensible price) and show new listings more prominently in search.
- *How we'll know it worked:* each month, count the share of homes with at least one review and the average reviews per home in each city. Both should go up.

3. Give hosts and investors price guides based on typical prices, never averages.

- *Why:* averages are pushed up by a few extreme listings, up to almost 3 times the typical price. Prices are also in 10 different currencies, so cities cannot be compared directly, and 113 listings show a price of zero.

- *What to do:* publish typical-price guides for each city, room type and home size (the dashboard's Pricing page already does this), and flag listings priced at zero or far above similar homes.
- *How we'll know it worked:* track how often the guide is used, how many listings are priced close to the typical price for their type, and whether the number of zero or extreme prices falls.

Limitations

- **We assumed the currencies.** The data does not say which currency each price is in, so we assumed each city uses its own. That is why prices are only compared within a city.
- **A price is what the host asks, not what they earn.** We do not know how often homes were actually booked, so nothing here measures income or profit.
- **A review shows that a guest stayed, not whether they were happy.** The review data has no written comments.
- **Some information is missing.** The district is blank for almost 9 in 10 homes, so we did not compare neighbourhoods across cities. About 4 in 10 hosts do not show a reply rate, so host figures describe only the hosts who do.
- **160 reviews appear twice,** each attached to two different homes. We kept them all rather than guess which home is correct.
- **2021 covers only January and February,** because the data ends on 1 March 2021.
- **These are patterns, not proof.** For example, busy homes having high ratings does not prove that one causes the other.

How the numbers were checked

Before trusting the dashboard, we recalculated its key numbers a second way, directly in the database, and every one matched: the number of homes, the number of reviews, typical and average prices for all 10 cities, and host reply and acceptance rates for every city. Two mistakes were caught and fixed along the way. Prices from different currencies were briefly being mixed on one page (fixed so that only one city can be selected at a time), and one chart carried a hidden filter left over from a copied page (removed). Full details are in the project log.